

Sermon Series Brief: *Holy Ground*

Dates: May 31 – June 28, 2026 (5 weeks)

Overview

Holy Ground is a five-week series that helps us appreciate how the biblical authors incorporate landscape in the meaning of their stories. Scripture has a strong sense of place. God meets people on mountains, in valleys, beside rivers, on seas, and in wildernesses, and the geography is never incidental to the encounter. Each setting carries its own theological weight, and each one says something specific about how God shows up.

The series invites the congregation to read these landscapes with fresh attention and to recognize them in their own lives. The mountain top is not just where Moses sees the land. The valley is not just where bones lie scattered. Riverside, sea, and wilderness are physical places in Scripture and recognizable seasons in the life of faith. The aim is to help hearers locate themselves in the terrain they are actually walking, and to trust that whatever ground they find themselves on, God has been there before them.

This series builds on the one Mountain Top sermon Woods preached last fall, expanding that single treatment into a full five-week arc.

The Goals of the Series

1. To help hearers attend to the geography of Scripture, recognizing how setting shapes meaning.
2. To name the spiritual seasons most of us actually move through, in language that takes those seasons seriously.
3. To frame the Christian life as a journey across varied terrain rather than a single posture to maintain.

Sermon Schedule

Week 1: Mountain Top (5/31)

Texts: Deuteronomy 3:1–2, 8–11; Psalm 133

The series opens on the mountain that feeds the land. Deuteronomy 3 traces the northern boundary of the conquered territory all the way up to Mount Hermon, and the text even pauses to note the names the surrounding peoples used for that peak. Psalm 133 picks up the same mountain and names what comes off of it: dew that runs all the way down to the mountains of Zion, where the Lord commands the blessing of life forevermore. That dew is more than imagery. Hermon's snowmelt and runoff feed the headwaters of the Jordan. Without what gathers on that summit, there is no river running through the valley and no land of milk and honey for Israel to walk into.

The mountain top in Scripture is a source. The view, the encounter with God, the unity, the oil running down Aaron's beard, all of it is meant to flow somewhere. We tend to want the mountain top to be a destination. Peter wanted to build shelters on the Mount of Transfiguration so the moment could be preserved. Moses had to come down even after he was given the view of the land. The gift of the summit is what it pours out onto the ordinary days that follow. The dew that runs down Hermon is the reason the land below has life at all.

Week 2: Shadow Valley (6/7)

Texts: Psalm 23

The most familiar psalm in the Bible spends most of its sentences describing accompanied terrain. The shepherd leads and restores. The shepherd is named long before the valley appears. By the time the psalmist enters the shadow, the question of whether he is alone has already been settled.

The valley in Psalm 23 is a real place. Tzalmavet is the deep shadow, the place where the light cannot quite reach all the way to the floor. Sheep country in the Judean wilderness has actual valleys like that. The psalm does not pretend they are not there. What the psalm refuses to do is treat the valley as the place where the shepherd is absent. Notice the grammar shift. The first verses speak of the shepherd in the third person: "He leads me, he restores me." The moment the valley shows up, the psalmist turns and speaks directly: "You are with me." The valley is where the language of God becomes the language of presence.

Week 3: Riverside (6/14)

Texts: Jeremiah 17:7–8; Psalm 1:1–3

The two texts share an image: a tree planted by water that does not fear drought because its roots reach the stream. The riverside is where formation happens quietly. It is where the conditions for life get established without much fanfare. This sermon attends to the slow work of being rooted in something that runs deeper than what the surface weather suggests. Possible direction: name the sources we are tempted to plant ourselves beside (productivity, news cycles, the approval economy of social feeds), and contrast their seasonal reliability with the kind of stream the prophet and the psalmist describe.

Week 4: The Sea (6/21)

Texts: Mark 4:35–41

The sea in Scripture is the place of chaos. Genesis begins with the Spirit hovering over deep waters. The Hebrew imagination treats the sea as the realm where order frays. Mark stages the disciples in a boat at night, in a storm strong enough to terrify men who fish for a living, and then has Jesus speak to wind and waves the way God spoke at creation. The disciples ask, "Who is this that even the wind and the sea obey him?" The sea is where calm has to be spoken into being.

Week 5: Wilderness (6/28)

Texts: Matthew 4:1–11; Numbers 10:11–36

Pairing Numbers with Matthew 4 reframes the wilderness from temptation site to formation territory. In Numbers, Israel is on the move. The cloud lifts and the people break camp. The cloud settles and the people stay. The wilderness here is a school for learning to follow. Matthew gives us Jesus in the same wilderness, formed by it before he begins his public ministry. The wilderness is not the absence of God's leading. It is the school in which God's leading is learned.